Contemporary Psychological Necessitation and the Trivialisation of Seriousness

An Existential, Phenomenological, Critical-Theoretical and Evolutionary Investigation

Abstract

This paper investigates contemporary psychological necessitation: the process through which externally established expectations become internally experienced necessities. It examines the paradoxical relationship between the increasing psychological importance of trivial activities and the diminishing capacity to preserve the significance of serious experiences. Drawing upon existentialism, phenomenology, critical theory, and evolutionary psychology, it develops an interdisciplinary account of how necessity, meaning, approval, attention, and individual agency are reorganised under modern social conditions. It argues that approval-seeking can become maladaptive when social signals cease to track cooperation, competence, safety, or other relevant outcomes. In such cases, the pursuit of approval may persist even when it undermines the individual's interests, collective problem-solving, or adaptation to changing conditions.

Keywords: *psychological necessitation; trivialisation; existentialism; approval-seeking; evolutionary mismatch; social conformity; attention; authenticity; significance displacement.*

1. Introduction: The Paradox of Contemporary Necessity

Contemporary society presents a complicated relationship between individual freedom and psychological obligation. Individuals have extensive access to information, communication, entertainment, and opportunities for self-expression. These possibilities coexist with perceived requirements concerning productivity, social participation, identity, emotional availability, and public recognition.

Why do individuals increasingly experience things that are not objectively necessary as though they are psychologically indispensable? Psychological necessitation describes the process through which an expectation, initially external to an individual, becomes internalised as an obligation governing behaviour and self-evaluation. Through repetition, social reinforcement, and anticipated consequences, participation can become experienced as something that must continue.

At the same time, experiences of substantial existential, moral, political, or personal importance compete for attention alongside ordinary and relatively insignificant events. This paper argues that psychological necessitation and significance displacement are interconnected: externally reinforced activities acquire subjective importance, while sustained attention towards matters of enduring importance becomes harder to maintain.

2. Kierkegaard: Levelling and the Disappearance of Individual Significance

In *The Present Age* (1846), Søren Kierkegaard examines *levelling*: the weakening of individual distinction and passionate commitment through an impersonal public. The public is not simply a collection of identifiable people; it is an abstract social force through which opinions, expectations, and judgements acquire authority.

An individual may become more concerned with how something is perceived than with its intrinsic significance. Expectations can become detached from the people who first established them: anonymous, yet psychologically powerful. A person may feel compelled to maintain an identity or participate in an activity without being able to identify who made that participation necessary.

When every matter is subjected to continuous public discussion and comparison, exceptional and ordinary concerns can become difficult to distinguish. Contemporary trivialisation can thus be interpreted as a technologically accelerated form of levelling.

3. Heidegger: Das Man, Idle Talk and the Loss of Authentic Significance

In *Being and Time* (1927), Martin Heidegger describes *das Man*, commonly translated as the anonymous 'they' or 'the one': the impersonal social world through which people inherit expectations about how one should behave, think, speak, and understand.

His analysis of everydayness includes *idle talk* (*Gerede*), the circulation of interpretations without necessarily achieving genuine understanding; *curiosity* (*Neugier*), the pursuit of novelty in which encountering something new can displace understanding; and *ambiguity* (*Zweideutigkeit*), the weakening of distinctions between genuine understanding and superficial familiarity.

Familiarity with a subject can become confused with understanding it. Knowing that an event has happened can feel equivalent to understanding why it matters. A serious event may be encountered, discussed, judged, and displaced without receiving sustained consideration. This is not Heidegger's own analysis of social media, but a contemporary application of his account of everydayness.

4. Nietzsche: Herd Mentality and the Revaluation of Importance

Nietzsche's critiques of herd morality in *The Gay Science* (1882) and *On the Genealogy of Morality* (1887) examine how values are formed and socially enforced. The question is whether individuals determine what is valuable or inherit valuations from the collective.

When importance is derived primarily from social reward, people may pursue recognition, popularity, productivity, or conformity because these activities are approved. The activity becomes important through its social consequences rather than its contribution to individual meaning. Necessity can emerge without explicit coercion: people voluntarily reproduce expectations that constrain them.

The trivialisation of seriousness can therefore be understood as a crisis of valuation. The problem is not that collective values are necessarily meaningless, but that their authority can become unquestioned.

5. Sartre: Bad Faith and the Internalisation of Obligation

In *Being and Nothingness* (1943), Jean-Paul Sartre describes *bad faith* as an evasion of the tension between freedom and facticity. People live within circumstances they have not entirely chosen, yet retain some freedom in how they interpret and respond to those circumstances.

Statements such as 'I have to remain constantly productive', 'I must maintain my social position', or 'I cannot afford to be different' may describe real pressures. They can also conceal the extent to which people have internalised and reproduced those pressures. Identity becomes organised around the obligations associated with a social role.

Psychological necessitation does not require freedom to disappear. It can operate through an individual's interpretation of freedom: the person becomes occupied with fulfilling expectations while losing sight of the capacity to evaluate them.

6. Debord and Baudrillard: Representation, Spectacle and Simulacra

Guy Debord's *The Society of the Spectacle* (1967) describes a social order in which representation mediates relationships and experience. The spectacle is not merely visual entertainment; it is a form of social organisation in which images and representations become central to how people relate to reality.

An event can acquire importance because it is represented as important. Visibility, circulation, and the capacity to generate participation may begin to determine perceived significance. A humanitarian crisis, for example, can become a succession of images, headlines, reactions, and temporary discussions. Exposure does not necessarily produce sustained understanding or commitment.

Jean Baudrillard's *Simulacra and Simulation* (1981) further examines how signs and representations can participate in producing the reality through which experiences are interpreted. Applied cautiously, this raises the possibility that people increasingly encounter socially constructed representations of importance. An activity may become important because it can be displayed, measured, and circulated.

7. Arendt: Thoughtlessness and Reflective Judgement

Hannah Arendt's *The Life of the Mind* (1978) examines thinking, willing, and judging. Her work helps distinguish intelligence or information possession from reflective examination. A person may possess considerable knowledge while failing to examine what that knowledge means for action and judgement.

The issue is not simply a lack of information. It is the separation of activity from reflective judgement. People may respond rapidly to demands without examining the assumptions that make those demands appear necessary. They can participate in discussions of serious subjects without sustaining the reflection that seriousness requires.

8. Han and Rosa: Achievement, Acceleration and the Loss of Resonance

Byung-Chul Han's *The Burnout Society* (2010; English translation 2015) argues that achievement-oriented environments encourage individuals to become managers of their own performance. External commands are partly replaced by self-imposed demands to optimise, improve, and demonstrate capacity. The person experiences these demands as personal aspiration even when they reproduce wider social expectations.

Hartmut Rosa's *Social Acceleration* (2005; English translation 2013) and *Resonance* (2016; English translation 2019) add a temporal dimension. Meaningful engagement requires time to respond, reflect, and be changed by an encounter. Under accelerated conditions, people may encounter more things while developing fewer sustained relationships with them. The experience is registered, but its capacity to transform the individual is interrupted.

9. Approval Without Adaptation: Evolutionary Mismatch and Maladaptive Social Signals

Approval-seeking is not inherently maladaptive. In small-scale social environments, sensitivity to acceptance, reputation, reciprocity, and exclusion could support cooperation and access to social resources. Approval can function as information: it may indicate that behaviour is trusted, competent, generous, or consistent with group expectations. But an evolved sensitivity to social feedback does not mean that every modern approval signal is adaptive, accurate, or worth pursuing.

An evolutionary-mismatch account distinguishes the psychological mechanism from the environment in which it operates. A disposition that was useful under some recurring ancestral conditions can produce poor outcomes when the scale, speed, incentives, or reliability of the environment change. Contemporary approval metrics—likes, follower counts, rapid reactions, rankings, and viral attention—can be weak proxies for durable cooperation, competence, truth, or wellbeing. They are measurable and immediate, but their relationship to those outcomes is contingent.

Consider several situations in which approval may cease to be adaptive. First, a person may repeat a popular but false claim because correction would threaten group acceptance. Second, an employee may display constant busyness because visible activity is rewarded, even when the performance reduces the time available for careful work. Third, a public figure may adopt increasingly extreme positions because outrage produces engagement, although polarisation damages trust and collective problem-solving. Fourth, a person may conceal uncertainty or avoid admitting error because the immediate social cost of disapproval feels greater than the longer-term cost of remaining wrong. Fifth, a group may punish dissent even when the dissenter identifies a real danger. In each case, approval is locally rewarding but may undermine the broader outcome that social approval would ordinarily be expected to support.

These are not examples of evolution stopping, nor proof that approval-seeking is genetically fixed. They illustrate a possible mismatch between evolved social sensitivities and contemporary reward environments. Natural selection does not guarantee that every behaviour is beneficial in every context, and it does not optimise individuals for modern digital platforms. Cultural practices and institutions can also evolve in ways that reward attention capture or conformity rather than accuracy, resilience, or collective benefit.

The phrase *non-evolutionary* therefore needs qualification. A behaviour can be evolutionarily intelligible in origin while being maladaptive in a particular present environment. It is more precise to describe such cases as *maladaptive*, *mismatched*, or *locally rewarded but globally costly*, rather than literally non-evolutionary. The distinction matters because approval can still be adaptive in other circumstances: cooperation, trust-building, learning from expertise, and maintaining reciprocal relationships remain socially valuable.

This section extends Kierkegaard's levelling and Nietzsche's herd critique. Approval can become a substitute for independent valuation: people infer that an action is worthwhile because it is rewarded, not because it is true, ethical, or consequential. Psychological necessitation occurs when the pursuit of approval becomes obligatory even where approval no longer tracks adaptive outcomes.

10. A Unified Theory: Psychological Necessitation and Significance Displacement

The philosophical perspectives can be brought together. Kierkegaard explains social levelling; Heidegger explains absorption into anonymous everyday expectations; Nietzsche questions inherited values; Sartre examines internalised obligation; Debord and Baudrillard analyse representation; Arendt highlights reflective judgement; Han examines self-imposed achievement demands; Rosa explains how acceleration can undermine sustained engagement; and evolutionary mismatch helps explain why approval mechanisms can be rewarded in contexts where they produce poor outcomes.

The proposed sequence is: social expectation; repeated exposure and reinforcement; internalisation; perceived necessity; attentional displacement; trivialisation of serious concerns; and renewed dependence on social approval. This is a conceptual model, not a claim that every individual or platform follows the same causal pathway.

Psychological necessitation may be represented as $Pn = E \times I \times R$, where E is the strength of external expectation, I the degree of internalisation, and R reinforcement through repetition. Significance displacement may be represented as $Sd = (Af \times U) / Cr$, where Af is attentional fragmentation, U the urgency of competing demands, and Cr reflective capacity. These expressions are heuristic: they identify proposed relationships, not validated measurement equations.

11. Recovering Seriousness: Authenticity, Reflection and Proportion

If psychological necessitation involves internalising socially established expectations, recovering autonomy requires reconsidering how importance is determined. Heidegger's account of authenticity invites people to recognise their own possibilities rather than allowing anonymous expectations to determine them entirely. Sartre emphasises responsibility for interpreting circumstances; Kierkegaard stresses individual commitment; Arendt highlights reflective judgement; and Rosa suggests that meaningful existence requires relationships with the world that exceed instrumental participation.

Three capacities are especially important: evaluative autonomy, the ability to distinguish meaningful commitments from inherited obligations; reflective continuity, the ability to sustain attention long enough to understand an experience; and existential proportion, the ability to distinguish urgency, visibility, and repetition from genuine importance.

The objective is not to reject ordinary activities, collective life, or social approval. It is to prevent them from becoming the exclusive determinants of psychological significance. Approval is useful when it provides credible information about trust, competence, or cooperation. It becomes dangerous when it is treated as an end in itself, regardless of its consequences.

12. Conclusion: The Necessity of the Trivial

Contemporary psychological necessitation describes a relationship between social expectation, internalised obligation, and individual agency. The philosophical tradition reveals that this is not merely a problem of distraction. It concerns how people acquire their sense of what matters, how social valuations become personal necessities, and how representation and approval can displace independent judgement.

The central paradox is that individuals can become increasingly occupied with activities that possess little enduring importance while becoming less capable of sustaining engagement with matters that genuinely matter. Triviality acquires the subjective characteristics of necessity. Seriousness loses the temporal, reflective, and existential conditions required to maintain its significance.

Approval-seeking sharpens the paradox. A response that can support cooperation in one environment may become maladaptive when detached from truth, competence, or collective wellbeing. The individual may be rewarded for conformity, visibility, or performance even when these behaviours undermine longer-term interests.

The fundamental question is therefore not simply whether individuals are free to choose what they do. It is whether they retain the capacity to determine why something should matter in the first place.

Central proposition

The trivial becomes necessary, the serious becomes ordinary, and approval can become an end detached from the outcomes that once made social approval useful.

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Theoretical qualification. Psychological necessitation and significance displacement are proposed constructs developed in this paper. The equations are heuristic rather than validated psychometric measures. The evolutionary discussion describes context-dependent mismatch, not a claim that modern behaviour is literally outside evolution. Philosophical works provide conceptual foundations, while empirical validation of the proposed framework remains a task for future research.